

Translating Qualitative Research Into Brand, Product, and Marketing Strategy

A confidential consulting case study on using consumer insights to shape positioning, messaging, product discovery, and customer experience.

At Thursday Strategy, I worked as a Qualitative Researcher supporting consumer insights and brand strategy projects for clients including Google, Chase, PrizePicks, and Air Canada.

Because the work was conducted under client confidentiality, this case study summarizes my role and research approach at a high level rather than sharing detailed findings, proprietary materials, or client artifacts.

Across projects, my work focused on understanding how people think, choose, react, and make meaning - then translating those insights into recommendations that could inform brand positioning, creative strategy, product discovery, campaign messaging, and go-to-market decisions.

Project Snapshot

Project / Client: Confidential consumer insights and brand strategy work for Google, Chase, PrizePicks, and Air Canada

Timeline: April 2025 – May 2026

Role: Qualitative Researcher

Team / Stakeholders: Thursday Strategy partners, client stakeholders, product teams, brand teams, marketing teams, innovation teams

Problem Space: Helping clients understand consumer behavior, brand perception, product discovery, purchase drivers, and creative concept performance

Methods: Focus groups, ethnographies, diary studies, interviews, rapid research, creative concept testing, discussion guide development, qualitative synthesis

Tools: Zoom, Google Workspace, Microsoft Office, UserInterviews, Listen Labs, [Discuss.io](#), Recollective

Outputs: Research plans, screeners, discussion guides, stakeholder updates, synthesis frameworks, executive-ready recommendations via executive documents and slide decks

Outcome / Impact: Supported product positioning, brand storytelling, campaign messaging, go-to-market planning, and customer experience strategy across confidential client workstreams

Focus Areas: Consumer insights, brand strategy, creative concept testing, product discovery, customer journeys, qualitative research

The Challenge

Many companies are not just trying to understand whether people like an idea. They are trying to understand why something resonates, where it falls flat, how it fits into people's lives, and what it means for the brand or product.

The challenge across my Thursday Strategy work was helping clients make sense of consumer behavior in fast-moving, often ambiguous contexts.

The work often centered on questions like:

How do people perceive this brand, product, or concept?

What language feels clear, credible, or motivating?

What moments influence consideration, trust, or purchase?

How do people describe their needs in their own words?

What should teams change before launch, campaign development, or broader rollout?

My Role

As a Qualitative Researcher, I supported research across multiple client workstreams at once.

My role included developing and refining discussion guides, supporting screeners and recruiting criteria, managing project timelines, preparing stakeholder updates, supporting or moderating research sessions, analyzing qualitative data, identifying patterns, and helping turn raw consumer feedback into clear recommendations.

I worked in a fast-paced consulting environment where the research needed to be both thoughtful and practical. The goal was not to produce research for research's sake — it was to help brand, marketing, product, and innovation teams make better decisions quickly.

Research Approach

The research approach varied by project, but most work followed a similar rhythm:

1. Clarify the business decision.

Before writing a guide or fielding research, we identified what the client needed to decide. This helped keep the research focused on strategy, not just feedback collection.

2. Translate business questions into research questions.

We turned broad client goals into questions participants could meaningfully respond to. For example, instead of only asking whether a concept was “liked,” we explored what felt clear, distinctive, believable, useful, confusing, or emotionally relevant.

3. Design the discussion flow.

I helped create guides that moved from broader context to more specific reactions. This allowed participants to first share their own behaviors, needs, and language before reacting to brand, product, or creative stimuli.

4. Capture nuance during fieldwork.

In qualitative research, the most useful insight is often not the first answer. I paid attention to contradictions, moments of hesitation, emotional language, and places where participants struggled to explain their reactions.

5. Synthesize patterns into recommendations.

After fieldwork, we looked for themes across participants, identified tensions, and translated findings into implications for product, brand, messaging, or customer experience.

Types of Work

Product and Feature Discovery

For technology-focused projects, I supported research exploring how people understand, discover, and evaluate emerging product experiences.

This work helped teams understand user expectations, points of confusion, perceived value, and the language people used to describe new or evolving products.

Brand and Positioning Research

For brand strategy projects, I supported research focused on perception, differentiation, relevance, and credibility.

The goal was to understand how people interpreted a brand or concept and what positioning felt most aligned with their needs, expectations, and motivations.

Creative Concept Testing

For creative and campaign work, I helped evaluate how people responded to messaging, visuals, narratives, and campaign ideas.

This included understanding what felt memorable, what felt generic, what drove interest, and what created confusion or skepticism.

Customer Journey and Decision-Making Research

For travel, financial services, and consumer product work, I supported research exploring shopper journeys, purchase drivers, trust, friction, and decision moments.

This work helped clarify what information people needed, what tradeoffs they were making, and what could move them closer to action.

Representative Client Work

Because the work is confidential, I would keep project descriptions high-level on the portfolio:

Google

Supported research related to product discovery, emerging technology, creative concepts, and public-facing launch moments. Work included studies connected to areas such as Gemini, Search / AI Mode, Pixel, and large-scale brand or campaign experiences.

Chase

Supported research related to financial product positioning, customer decision-making, and travel / rewards experiences, including work connected to Chase Aeroplan.

PrizePicks

Supported consumer research tied to brand perception, positioning, and rebrand strategy.

Air Canada

Supported research exploring traveler behavior, customer decision-making, and brand or product experience opportunities.

What Made the Work Challenging

The work often moved quickly. Projects required balancing rigor with speed, especially when teams needed recommendations in time for strategy, campaign, product, or launch decisions.

It also required translating messy qualitative feedback into something useful for stakeholders. Participants might react emotionally, contradict themselves, or struggle to explain why something did or did not resonate. My job was to help make sense of those patterns without flattening the nuance.

Research-to-Strategy Impact

Across projects, my work helped support recommendations related to:

- Product positioning**
- Brand storytelling**
- Campaign messaging**
- Go-to-market planning**
- Customer journey improvements**
- Concept refinement**
- Consumer decision-making**
- Product discovery and adoption**

The value of the work came from helping teams better understand how people interpreted their ideas before making larger investments in product, marketing, or brand decisions.

Reflection

Thursday Strategy helped me broaden my research lens beyond traditional UX usability work.

I became more interested in the spaces where UX research overlaps with brand strategy, marketing, product management, and customer experience. The work reminded me that people do not experience products only through interfaces. They experience them through language, expectations, brand associations, social context, advertising, customer support, and the moments that happen before and after use.

It also strengthened my ability to move quickly, manage ambiguity, and turn qualitative nuance into recommendations that business teams could act on.

What I'd Do Differently Today

If I were building a portfolio artifact from this work, I would create a sanitized “representative project” that shows my process without revealing client IP.

For example, I would create a mock case study showing:

Business question

Research objective

Method selection

Discussion guide structure

Synthesis approach

Insight hierarchy

Strategic recommendation format

That would allow recruiters to understand how I think without exposing confidential work.

Project Card

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Supported confidential consumer insights and brand strategy research for clients including Google, Chase, PrizePicks, and Air Canada. Conducted and synthesized qualitative research across creative concept testing, product discovery, brand perception, customer journeys, and go-to-market strategy.

Qualitative Research · Consumer Insights · Brand Strategy · Creative Concept Testing · Product Discovery · Go-to-Market Strategy · Customer Journey Research · Focus Groups · Ethnography · Diary Studies · Research Synthesis · Executive Storytelling